

the REUBYTE

a Reuby mini-issue, TT24



featuring works by:

Katherine Faulkner | Alyina Rizwan Hashmi | Valley Lopez | Mauricio Reyna-
Jeldes | Jennifer Rai | Jayroop Ramesh | Daniel Revach | Puyu Wang

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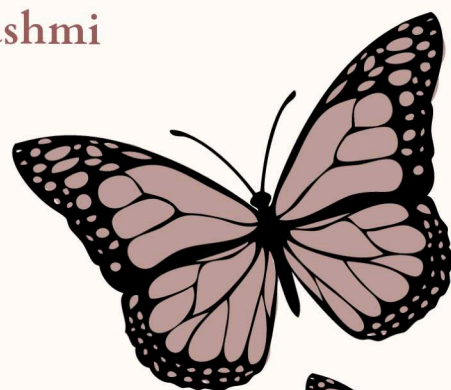
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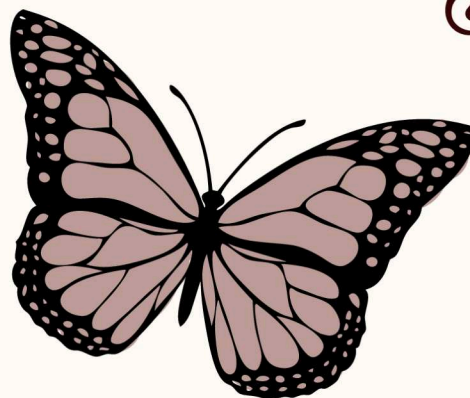
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Cover image by
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only the most exciting announcements

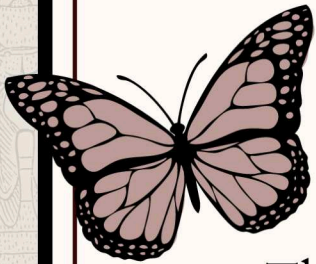
(we promise!)

Want to be published but didn't get a chance to feature in this issue? Not a problem – submit to the Reuby yearly issue! Send your piece to thereuby@reuben.ox.ac.uk.

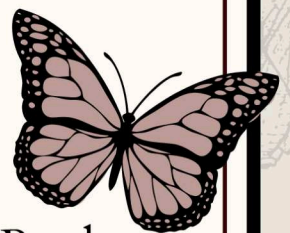
Guidelines can be found on our webpage at <https://reuben.ox.ac.uk/reuby-student-magazine>



Want to join our fabulous editorial team? Drop us an email.



The Reuby has its very own Instagram page [@the_reuby](https://www.instagram.com/the_reuby) – check us out and follow!



The Reuby magazine is officially registered as a Reuben college society! Why does this matter? We're not sure! But expect big and exciting projects.

letter from the & EDITORS



“Everything changes, nothing perishes.”

These words from Ovid’s epic *Metamorphoses* ring ever so true as we stand at the threshold of the 21st century and the third millennium, witnessing the world transform in every possible way. But this growth and change happen within us as well, as our biological, cultural, and personal pasts flow through our being and into the future, inviting us to lead or follow, resist or accept. Shall we rise to the occasion, or rather repeat the wise suggestion by Kafka’s sales-agent-turned-insect: How about if I sleep a little bit longer and forget all this nonsense?

For our first ‘Reubyte’ ever, a low-key and informal mini-issue of the magazine, the Reuby invited all Reuben members – students, fellows, and staff – to submit their work broadly related to the theme of “metamorphosis”. Contributors were asked to consider this theme, but they had the freedom to interpret that idea in whichever way that resonated with them while keeping in mind the (possibly apocryphal) ideas of Heraclitus in:

“The only constant in life is change”.

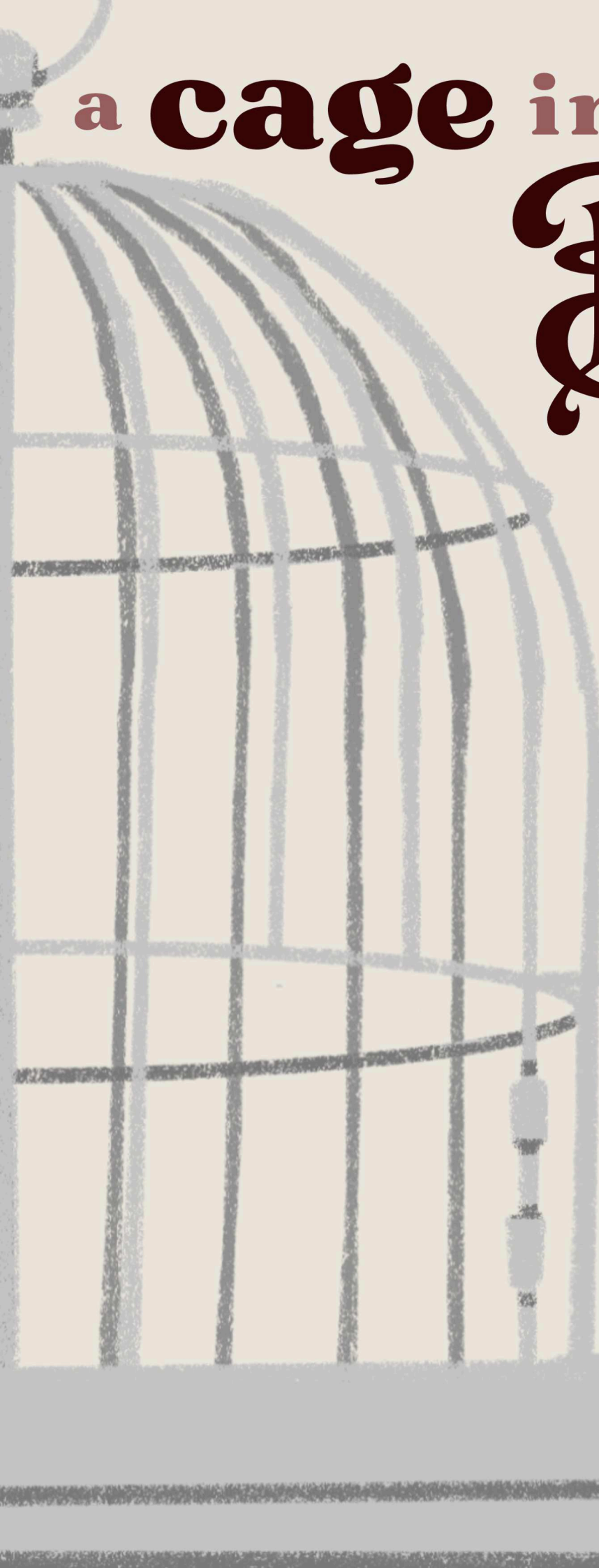
While curating this edition and coming up with a concept for the ‘Reubyte’, we looked to the penny dreadfuls and pulp magazines of yesteryear. We aimed to encapsulate and elevate the startup nature of our college and the avant-garde, evolutionary and/or revolutionary ideas of our community as best as we could. Because, as Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa says in *The Leopard*:

“If we want things to stay as they are, things will have to change”.



All AI art generated by Puyu Wang





a cage in search of a BIRD

Katherine Faulkner
DPhil Environmental Research

They say to never meet your heroes, but do we ever consider if our heroes want to meet us? I arrived at the GCR on the 6th of May to learn about the life and literature of Franz Kafka. Since I already read *The Trial* for a class and *Metamorphosis* for pleasure, I knew some facts about the author already. Specifically, I knew Kafka's work was absurdist. *The Trial* always stuck with me because it reminds me of dreams where you cry out for help, but no one notices or cares.

I also already knew Kafka's work was largely unfinished. Kafka wanted to write in a flow state, so most of his work is either short or unfinished. This is likely due to his perfectionism. If he was not happy with his work on the first try, then he would abandon it. This heightens the absurdism. Not only is it unfinished, but it is all written in one go without many major revisions. We are reading a man's unfiltered thoughts.

It surprised me then that Kafka's will ordered all unpublished writings to be burned. Yet, 90% of his unpublished materials are housed in the Bodleian.

How?

His will was not obeyed.

Kafka's work instead went to be published.

Hearing this reminded me of our History of Science Museum. There, you will see a chalkboard displaying Albert Einstein's writing. Einstein was also someone who did not want his work to be idolized, yet we proudly display his notes. Oxford is not alone. My high school's math club sent Einstein flowers, to which he responded with a thank you letter. This is now in my hometown's natural history museum.

All of this makes me wonder: should we respect the author or kill them?

Kafka's work takes the control away from his protagonist, and now Kafka has no control of his own narrative. In this way, Kafka's life is Kafkaesque.



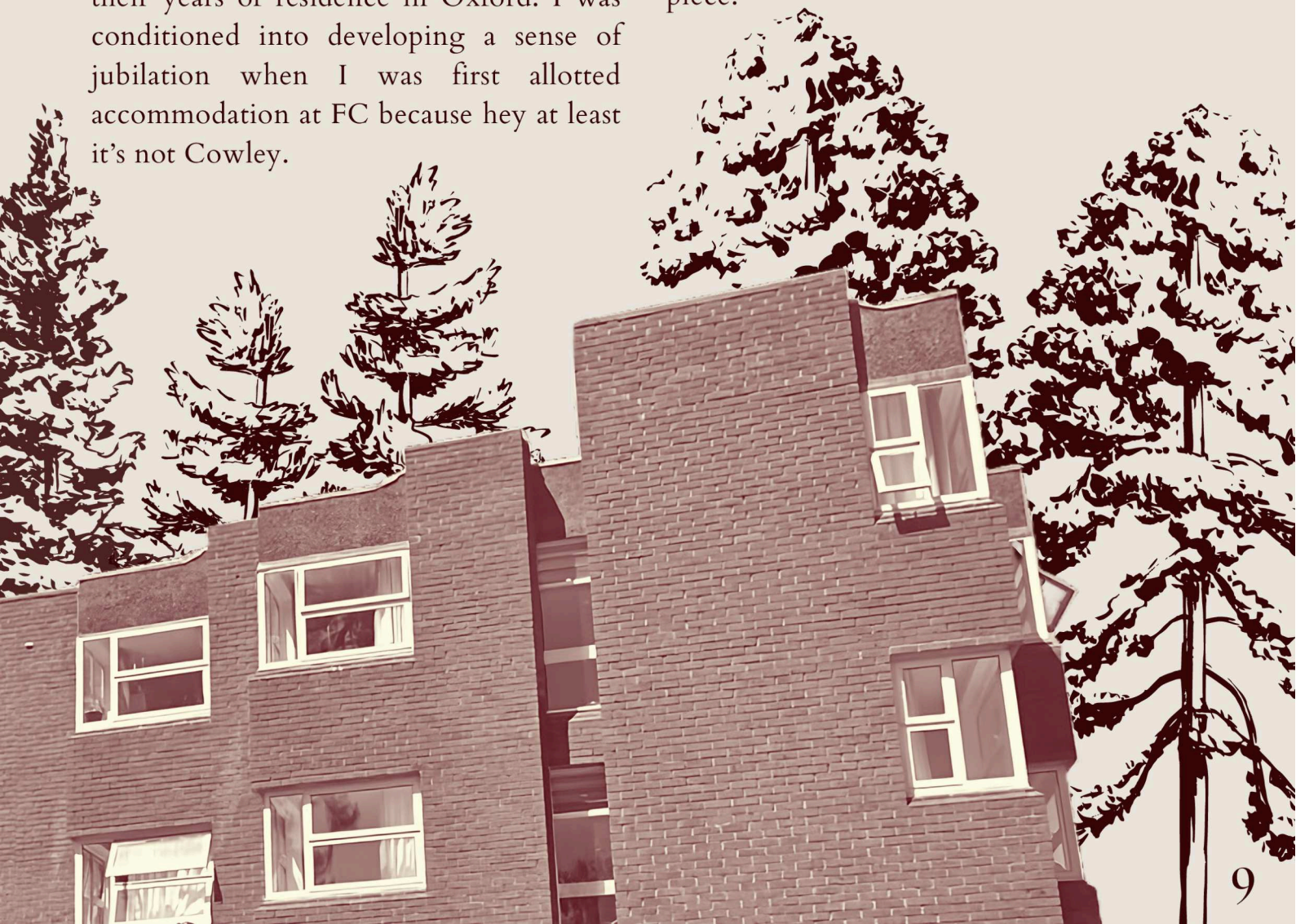
confessions of a FARNDONITE

Alyina Rizwan Hashmi

MSc Water Science, Policy and Management

Nestled between what the wider world thinks of as the distant realm of Summertown and what those who know better recognize as a more accessible location in North Oxford is Reuben's most extensive student housing: Farndon Court. Replete with a classic red-brick façade and curtains a shade of grey drearier than this country's weather, FC is where the majority of Reubenites begin their years of residence in Oxford. I was conditioned into developing a sense of jubilation when I was first allotted accommodation at FC because hey at least it's not Cowley.

This jubilation was replaced by disbelief when I first stepped into my all-too-humble abode—the room was giving tiny Hong Kong apartment energy. By all accounts, however, I still had reason to be grateful: an OX2 postcode, sleeping only a stone's throw away from the Summertown houses that would cost three lifetimes worth of savings, and hey at least it wasn't Cowley. Almost 8 months into my time here, I can no longer contain my thoughts on life at FC and am therefore compelled to write this piece.



It is impossible to write about FC—and yes, I am also disconcerted about this abbreviation, the urge to mentally add a B after the FC is too real—without delving into its most prominent and loudest feature. Farndon Court is equipped with what is arguably the world’s most sensitive smoke detection system. This intricate network undergoes tests more frequently than I did through my degree programme, a practice for which I am singularly grateful since the 10 am alarm test ensured I was never late for my Wednesday lectures. However, this fire alarm’s distinctiveness does not only lie in the fact that I couldn’t sleep through it but also in its remarkable sensitivity. Someone on the fourth floor—and it was ALWAYS the fourth floor—aspiring to be the next Gordon Ramsey? *angry alarm noises* An extended steamy shower in one of the fourth-floor showers? *must evacuate building* Fourth floor resident exhaled a bit too intensely? *code red* Some might say the 21st century college really did go all out in installing 21st century fire alarms. At its worst point, it seemed like we were living in a modern version of the boy—or alarm, in this case—who cried wolf. We were SO over it, we wouldn’t have reacted to a real fire if it came right to our doorstep. An anonymous GCR exec member confesses that the (false) alarm still rings in his head: “Not sure if it’s PTSD or because I live next door”. If I could have 100,000 pounds for every fire alarm activation incident at FC...I still wouldn’t have enough to move into one of those Summertown houses :(but you get the gist.

Speaking of money, I am convinced that FC’s budget for those nasty blue acids to unclog shower drains must rival the magnitude of certain college endowments. My email history to the facilities manager is testament to the fact that the shower drains were just NOT draining, especially in Michaelmas term. The culprit? Hair, in most cases but for those in shared bathrooms, the real question was WHOSE hair? I empathize with this desire to find someone to blame, knowing that the comfort busy postgraduates derive from identifying a villain comes much more easily than the effort-intensive satisfaction gained from actually emailing Ray to come in with his acid arsenal. Go for the low hanging fruit, to phrase it in MBA language. However, it wasn’t all that simple: one resident confirmed that for bathrooms shared by people with similar hair colours, that one flatmate—and I know you can all think of one—had to conduct a length analysis on strands to pick who to blame. Admittedly, the shower drain crisis was a great test of friendship; I must also report that the situation improved a great deal in Hilary term so perhaps future generations of Farndonites can skip this test of character.



It is a truth universally acknowledged that college accommodations are a great place to network. Not just for purposes that Jane Austen would approve of but also for those amongst us who are forgetful or just like to travel light, i.e., people who leave their BOD card at home. In order to safeguard my career prospects, I will never publicly admit to the number of times I've been locked out of FC but it has taught me to expand my network...all over the building so that I know at least someone who can let me in if other people are unavailable. Interestingly, this has also revealed which degree programmes have students who are most likely to stay at home most of the time—shoutout to our resident physicists!

Because it is always nice to end essays, even those as whiny as this one, on a sentimental note, I will say that I am beginning to internalize the merits of FC now that my tenancy is coming to an end. My sense of appreciation mostly stems from having to explore options in Cowley *shudders*. Occasionally when the weather is tolerable, I will admit that it's hard to find a reason to complain when you step out to the calm tree-lined pavement of Farndon Road and look at the evening sky painted in cotton candy hues, clouds outlined with a classic golden hour gleam, a gentle breeze caressing the back of your neck. During sunsets like these, an FC resident can only think of one thought: hey at least I'm not in Cowley.





terra FACTA

Valley Lopez
MSc Nature, Society and
Environmental Governance

Shiya paints the quiet city.

Up and down deserted streets, through sprawling parking lots, on the sides of mansions and gleaming skyscrapers, on curbs and fences and gates and signs - colors cover the vacant metropolis in a frolicking swirl of wandering, crisscrossed lines. There is no meaning to the scrawl; it is an improvised dance, a random, psychedelic unfolding of synthetic rhizomes. A loop here, a crisscross there, a scattered collection of right angles. Shiya fills the city with these shapes and more, moving through a haze of acetone and magnesium silicate, dancing to the spray can's rattle-tap tune.



The doors of the building are stamped with the words TERRA FACTA. Below the bold blue characters, slightly fading on the gray metal paneling, are two red exclamation marks and a black and yellow symbol indicating radioactivity. A tall, narrow metal locking mechanism joins the seam between the two door panels. It is pockmarked with rust and grime, and cobwebs cover its surface, swaying in the gentle afternoon breeze. With a hiss from their spray can nozzle, Shiya paints a patchwork of green and purple lines across the doors.

Off to the outer edge of the left-hand door, below one of its massive steel hinges, a thick piece of jagged metal has been peeled back to reveal an opening into the building. Moving towards it, Shiya positions themselves for a better look inside. After a moment's hesitation, they begin to move through the crudely fashioned gap, wary of the sharp metal edges.

Once inside, Shiya is confronted by complete and total darkness. The building has no windows, and no light trickles in from their point of entrance. They are immediately aware of a sharp, foul smell of lingering decay.

It mingles with something thick and meaty, almost earthy. As they move further into the building to investigate, they bump into something hard and tubular. It goes clacking away before it settles into silence.

Their eyes now adjusting, Shiya sees that the room is not entirely cloaked in darkness. Flickering gold spots are randomly scattered before them, suspended in the air. The spots have a hexagonal shape, and a depth, like the empty honeycombs of a bees nest. These “containers” (if they can be called that) are slowly drifting in all directions. As Shiya inspects the one nearest to them, all the containers brighten, bathing the room in a soft golden glow.

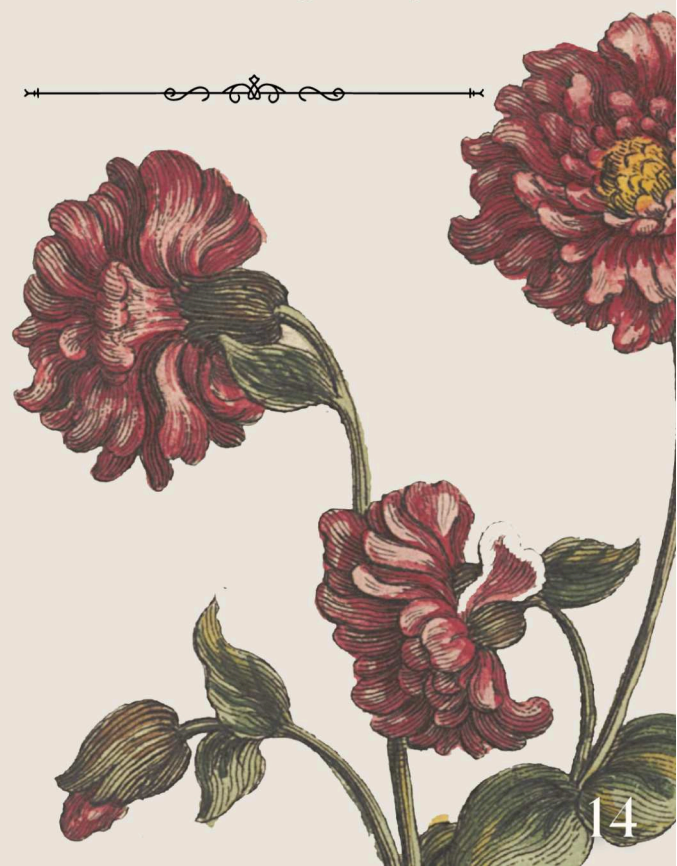
They can now see a hallway, stretching out and beyond the reaches of the light. In every corner and on every inch of floor, there are bones. Thousands and thousands of bones, arranged in a single layer. Some are long and smooth; some are short and lined with ridges. Others twist and curve around upon themselves. All the bones are aligned in parallel patterns, pointing towards the center of the room.

A massive black sphere is positioned there, cradled on a silver circular base. The sphere appears to be made of a porous yet sturdy metal material, and a latticework of the same honeycomb-like patterns from the floating lights is etched on its surface. Each of the individual hexagonal shapes are rising and falling in alternating rhythms. As the hexagons move outwards, a burst of white and orange light emanates from the space exposed beneath them.

As they move inward, the light disappears. These “cycles” take about five seconds in total, each one accompanied by a hissing of forcefully expelled air.

Moving closer to the sphere, crunching amidst the bones, Shiya can make out a distant, garbled sound, slowly rising in volume. It modulates through low and high frequencies, constantly shifting in pitch and timbre. Embedded deeper in the sound is a voice, but one without structure or syntax. It is a cry, growl, laugh, moan, and scream. It has a carnal, pleading quality that is both compelling and repellent, vast and insignificant, contained and unbounded. Without saying a single word, the voice speaks to something so ancient that it extends beyond the boundaries of time and language. It speaks of life and death and meanings and universes in a single sound.

Shiya lifts their spray can to the sphere’s surface and begins to paint.



There's a burst of orchids on the overpass. A smattering of hydrangeas in the gutter. Lines of tulips on streetlights, circles of lilies on brick. There are carnations in the subway, lavender in the landfill, zinnia on smokestacks, roses around the shipyard, and dahlias across the bridge. Hibiscus trails from rooftops. Marigolds dot the school yard and chrysanthemums cover the pitch. Daffodils trickle through windows. Supermarkets fill with hyacinth.

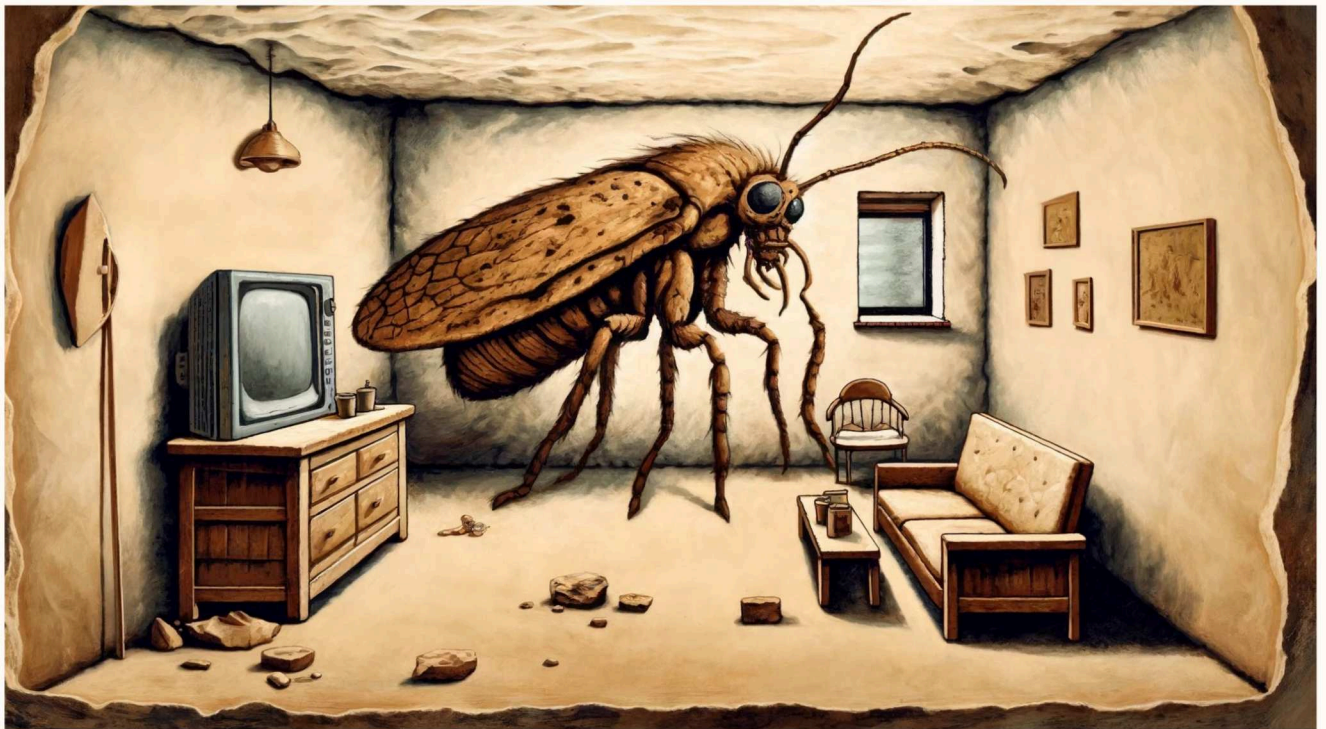
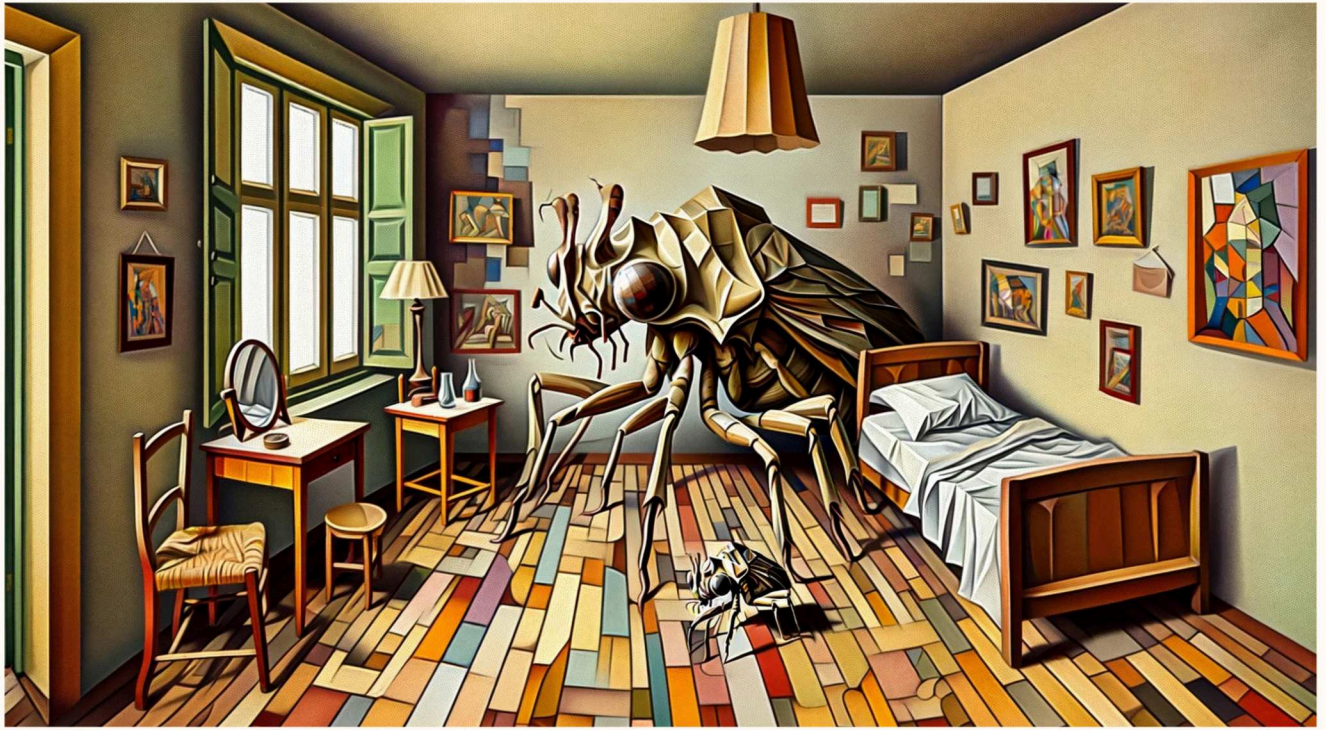
Further out, beyond the sprawl, the concrete edges of the city begin to fold and settle into the wide-open fields. Sycamore and silver birch burst through the breeze blocks of countryside cottages. Ash and alder sprout along hedgerows. Giant puffball mushrooms gather at the base of power lines, mixing with chanterelle, tawny grisette, and shaggy ink caps. Beneath the topsoil there is a tumultuous blending of mycelium, phosphorus, arsenic, microfiber, and hormones. They bond and morph into one another, gathering on the riparian zones of rivers before being carried away downstream.

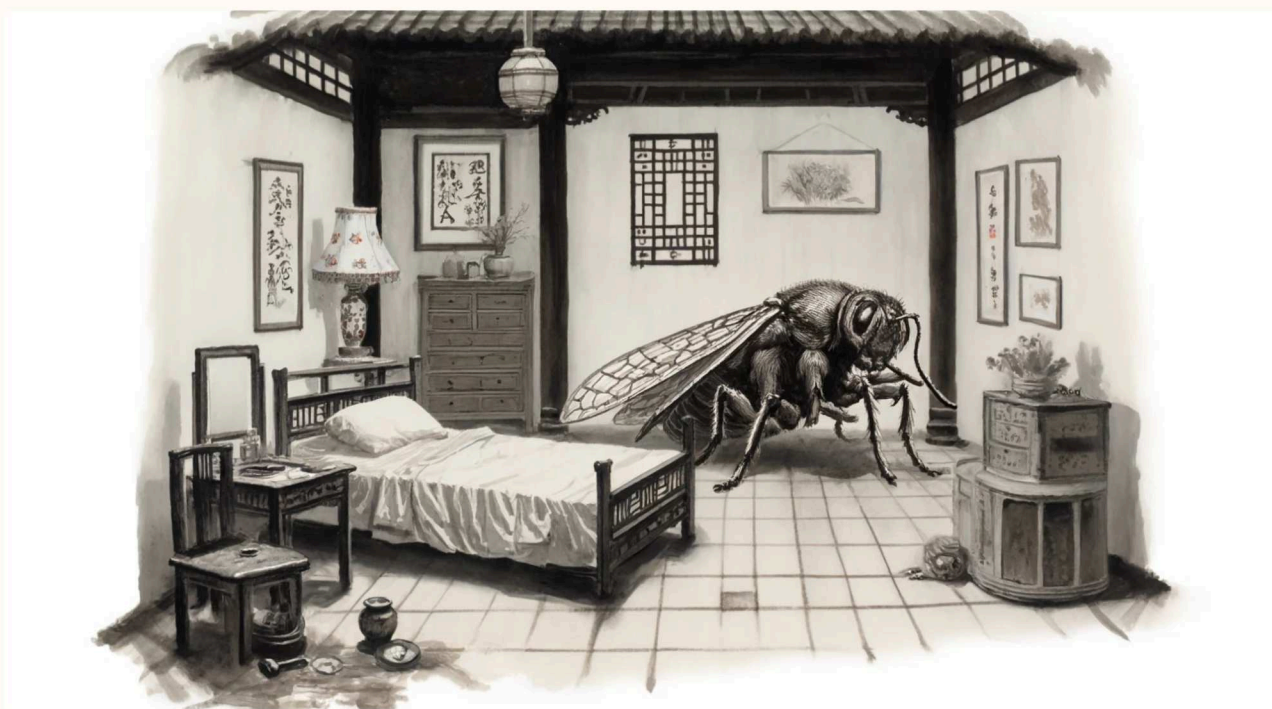
On the horizon, clumped and throbbing, a sea of bodies crests the mountaintops. The earth shakes with the sound of their approach. A million hooves, claws, feet, and paws pound and tramp the ground, moving towards the outskirts of the city. Above them, the humming of a billion wings beats the air. Mayflies, starlings, wood pigeons, moths, short-eared owls, beetles, and bats co-mingle. They swoop and flit among wild boars, red deer, pine martens, and grass snakes, jostling for space.

Shiya roars. They gallop to meet the oncoming crowd, their beak clattering, gills pulsing, snout flared, antennae pointed to the sky. At the moment species meet, Shiya's minds expand and multiply, filling with the lives they have known, and expanding into the ones they have not yet lived. They feel the wind on the mountaintops, hear the creak of the ancient forest, taste the salt in the desert rain. They know each of the water droplets in the clouds and all the grains of sand in the deepest part of the sea. They move beyond the city. They *become*.

Shiya reaches outward, wrapping themselves around the sun.







primaeterna

Mauricio Reyna-Jeldes DPhil Oncology

Under the song of branches,
rocked by a cotton beat,
mother and son forge a trail
made by textile veil,
springtime's music sheet,
a new cycle for heaven and earth.



hesitations

Jayroop Ramesh DPhil Computer Science
Reuby Senior Editor

Does the sun not heave a sigh,
draped in weariness after,
burning in perpetuity and,
carrying light and hope,
for the heavens above?

Does the moon not heave a sigh,
robed in fatigue, after,
glowing in serenity and,
bringing luster and dreams,
to the world below?

Does the soul not heave a sigh,
wrapped in exhaustion after,
striving in banality and,
bearing hope and dreams,
from the universe within.



a metal PRISON

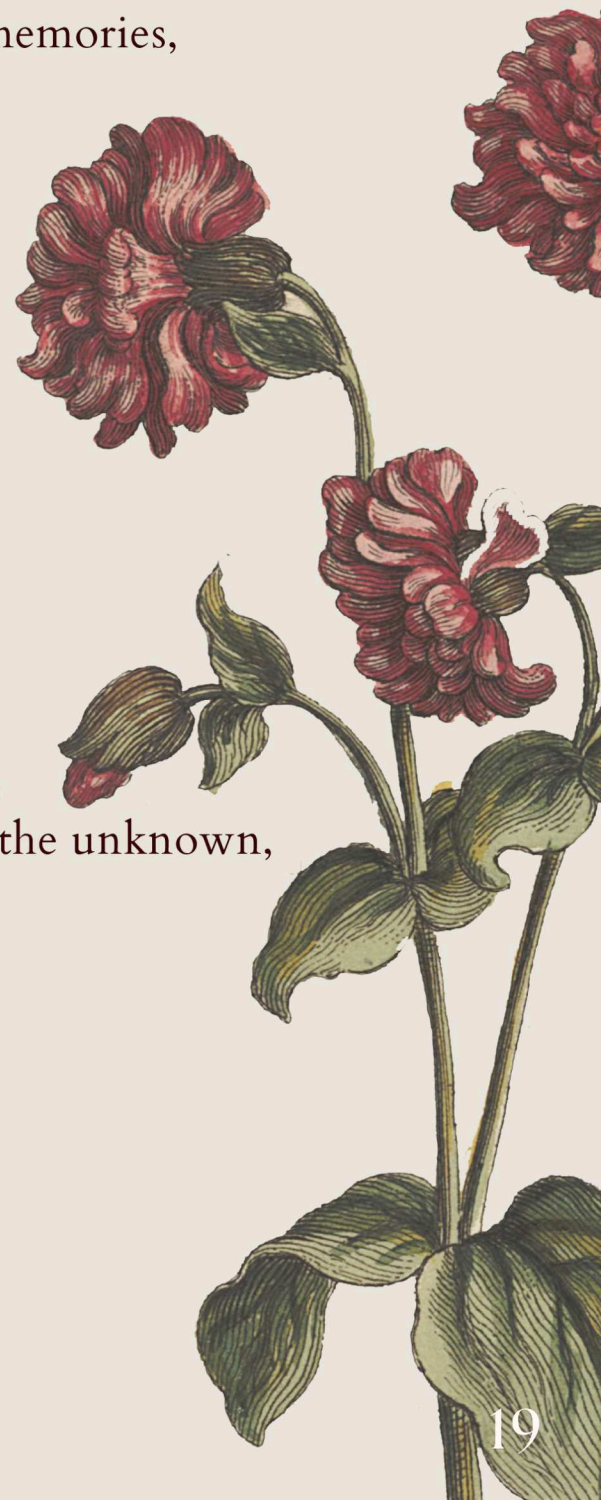
Jennifer Rai MSc Radiobiology

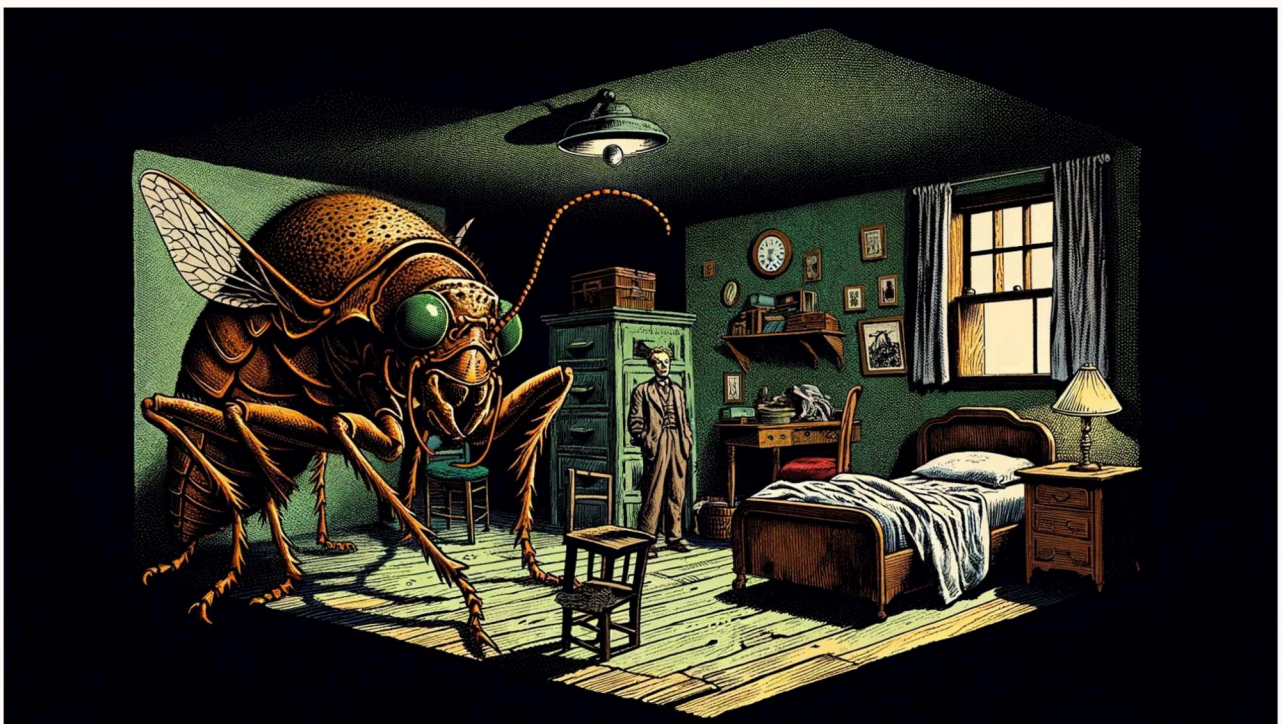
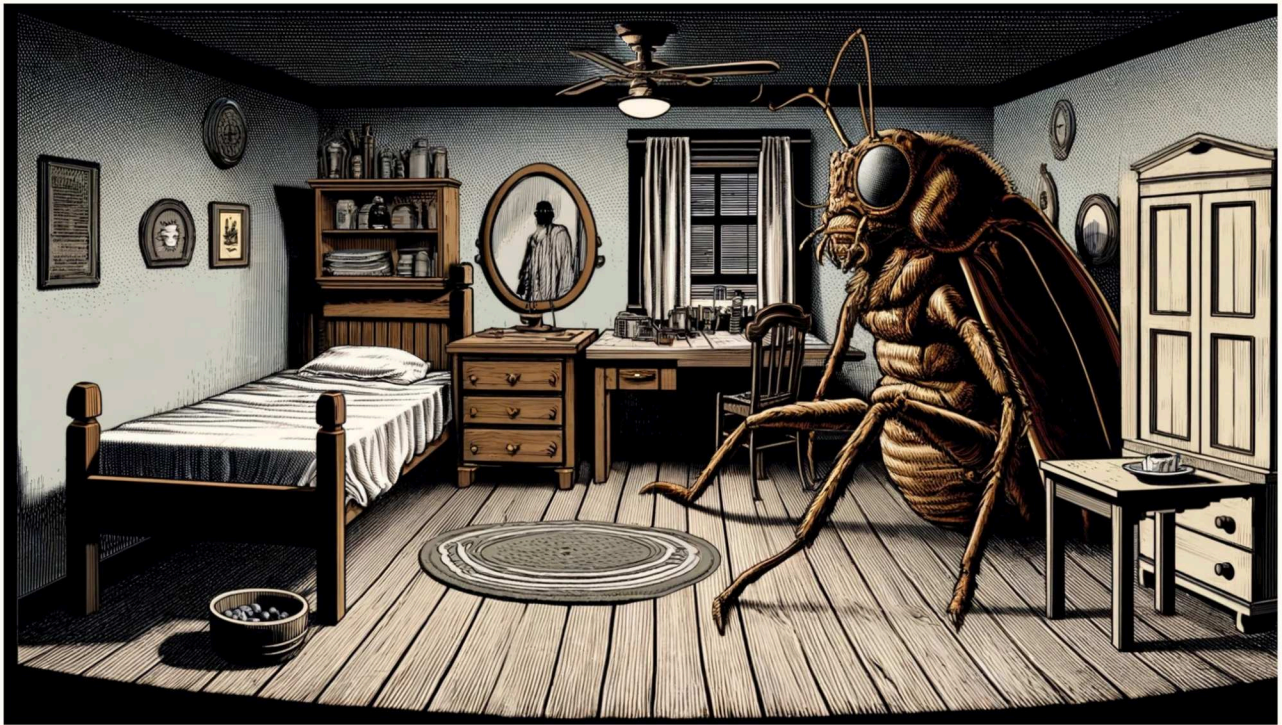
Alone. You think you are,
as you clutter and clamber through endless memories,
of forgotten love and life,
that now seem afar.
Each photo leaves a permanent scar.

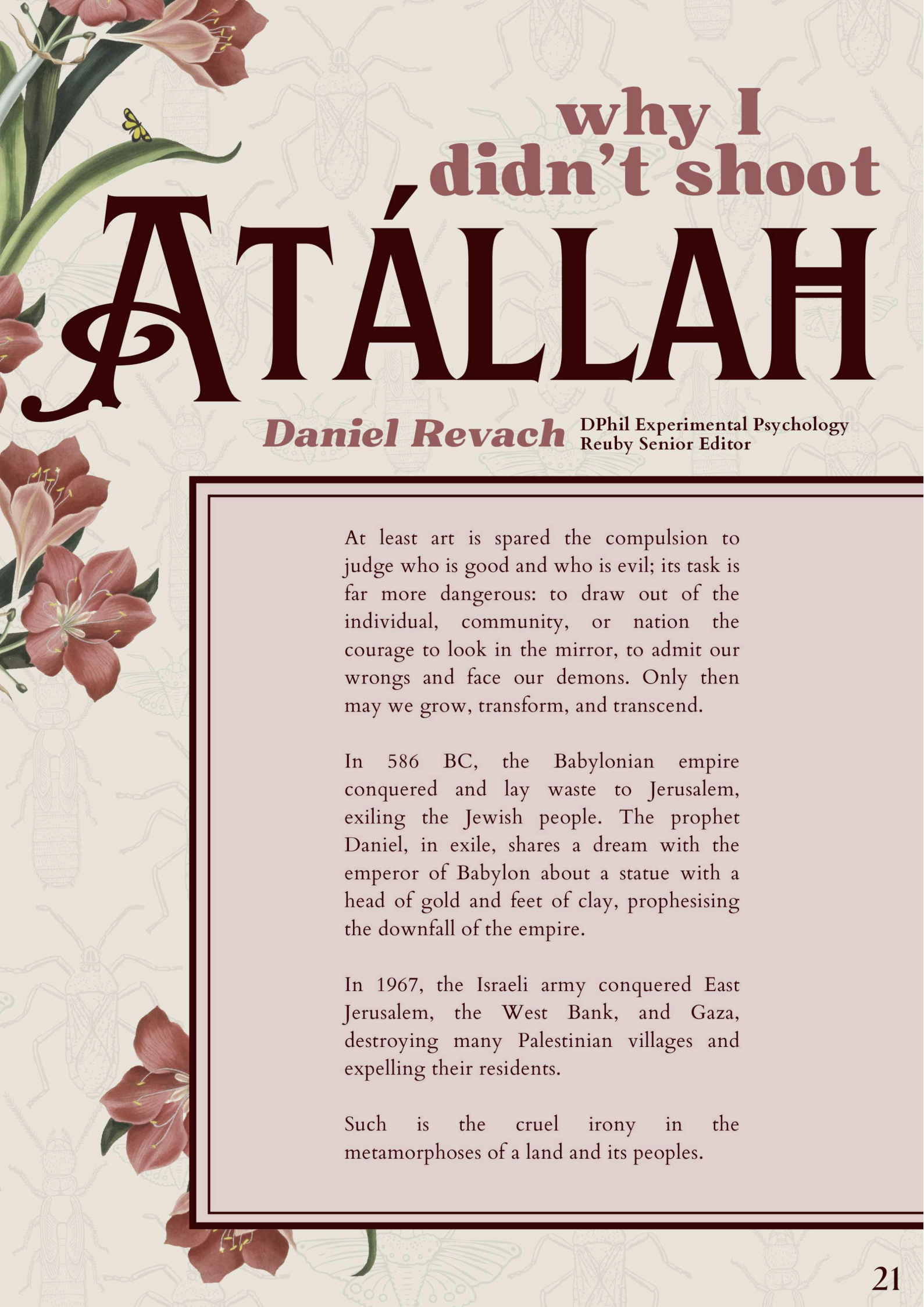
Seconds turn into months
and disappear without a trace,
tears begin to roll down your face,
as you imagine yourself without a frame.
Why do you hang your head in shame?

While I carefully help you get up,
your years of motherhood appear as a vision,
holding a small hand through the jungles of the unknown,
a little child begins to groan,
with kindness and care, you console.

Those tiny palms are now much bigger,
the child that looked up, at you
now, looks down,
at your chair,
where you sit.
A metal prison.







why I didn't shoot ATÁLLAH

Daniel Revach

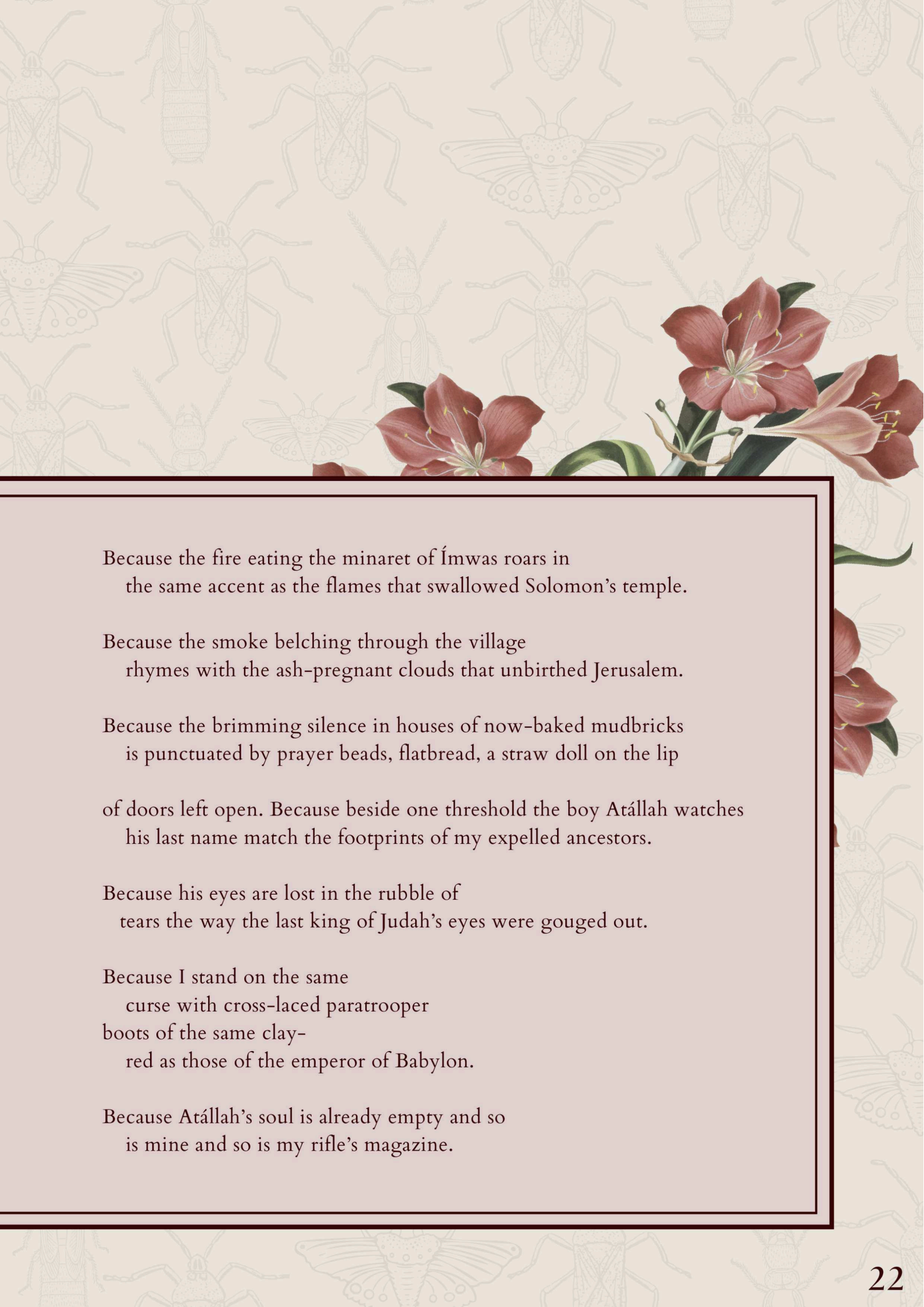
DPhil Experimental Psychology
Reuby Senior Editor

At least art is spared the compulsion to judge who is good and who is evil; its task is far more dangerous: to draw out of the individual, community, or nation the courage to look in the mirror, to admit our wrongs and face our demons. Only then may we grow, transform, and transcend.

In 586 BC, the Babylonian empire conquered and lay waste to Jerusalem, exiling the Jewish people. The prophet Daniel, in exile, shares a dream with the emperor of Babylon about a statue with a head of gold and feet of clay, prophesising the downfall of the empire.

In 1967, the Israeli army conquered East Jerusalem, the West Bank, and Gaza, destroying many Palestinian villages and expelling their residents.

Such is the cruel irony in the metamorphoses of a land and its peoples.

The background of the page features a repeating pattern of various insects, including beetles, moths, and flies, rendered in a light, sketchy style. Overlaid on the right side of the page are several vibrant red lilies with yellow centers and green leaves.

Because the fire eating the minaret of Ímwas roars in
the same accent as the flames that swallowed Solomon's temple.

Because the smoke belching through the village
rhymes with the ash-pregnant clouds that unbirthed Jerusalem.

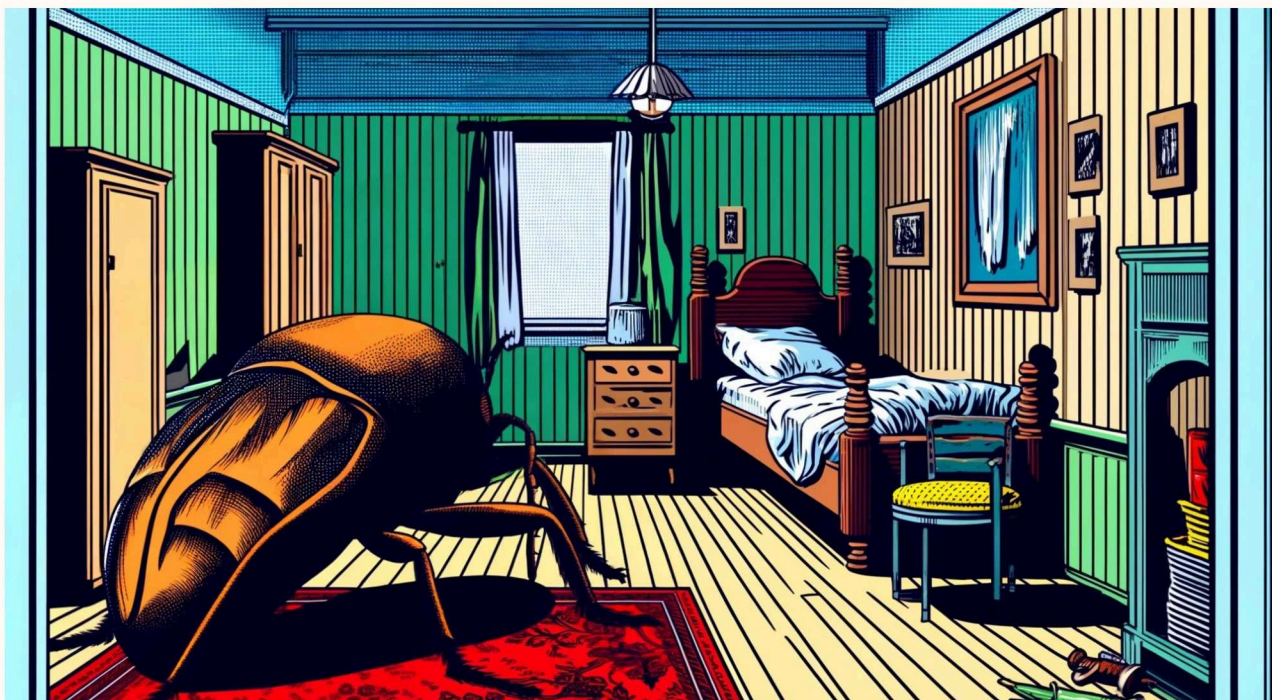
Because the brimming silence in houses of now-baked mudbricks
is punctuated by prayer beads, flatbread, a straw doll on the lip

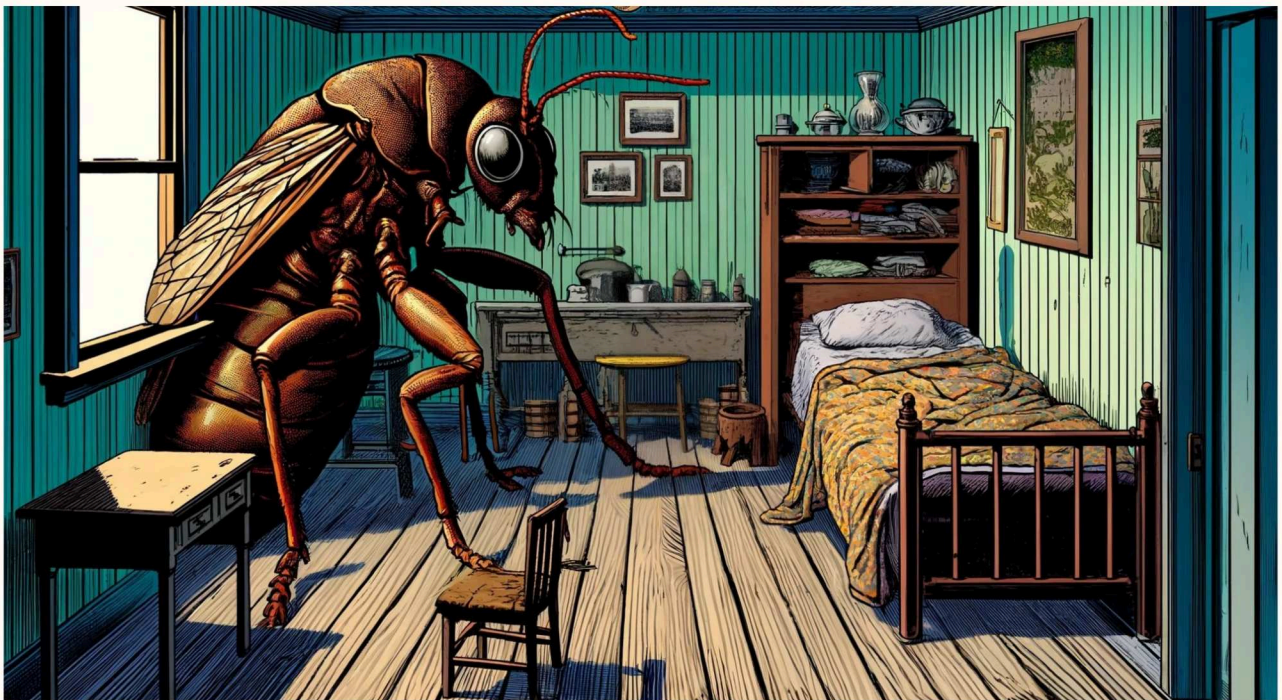
of doors left open. Because beside one threshold the boy Atállah watches
his last name match the footprints of my expelled ancestors.

Because his eyes are lost in the rubble of
tears the way the last king of Judah's eyes were gouged out.

Because I stand on the same
curse with cross-laced paratrooper
boots of the same clay-
red as those of the emperor of Babylon.

Because Atállah's soul is already empty and so
is mine and so is my rifle's magazine.





meet the team

Jayroop Ramesh
editor

Daniel Revach
editor

Alyina Hamshi
editor

Eliza Rayner
creative director and graphic design

Katherine Faulkner
outreach

Puyu Wang
IT and visual art

Songqi Li
social media

a wordsearch

M S L Q N K L J C Z A V L T P M W R W A R B Q
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Y C E B I R T H E X L I M K T G N M C C S R Q
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G K G N U R G A M E S A C U P P Y A E M M W O
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J L S P O T S N O F V F H N H B C U I O M A D
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C C H O M E Q O Z X E J K O X K P L N G E C C
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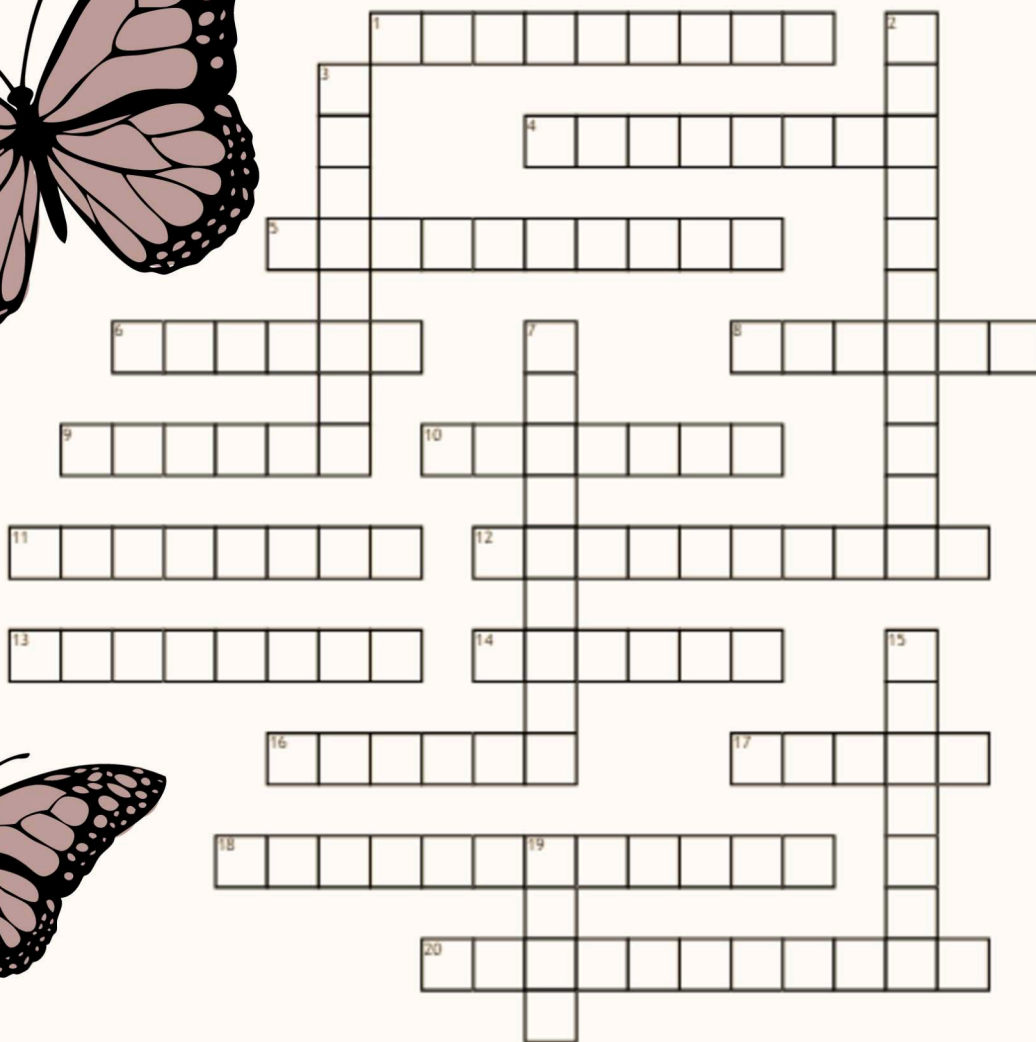
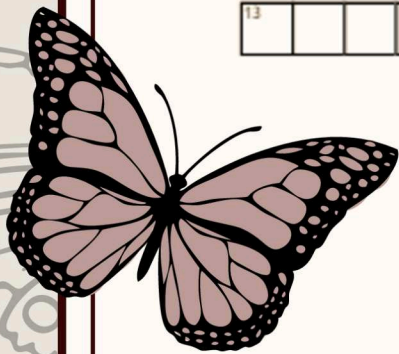
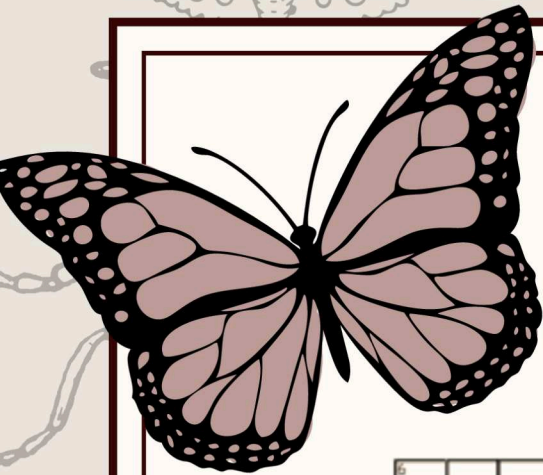
on the theme of metamorphosis

caterpillar	bestfriend	garden	checkers	anthony
hardwork	colourful	games	morning	home
leafbug	lively	cracking	spots	
wings	birth	carmelo	stem	
lazy	ant	cocoon	clubhouse	

You can find the answers on our webpage and Instagram!



a crossword



Across

1. A showing little or no emotion or animation not interested or concerned
4. A design composed of one or more letters, typically the initials of a name, used as an identifying mark
5. A distressing to the feelings affecting the emotions or mental appeal
6. noxious animals that are hard to control
8. a chair for at least two people, has a back and arms

9. Rorschach ink _____ test
10. abrupt in manner or blunt
11. affected by coma or lacking alertness or energy
12. the quality of being sharp or harsh to the senses
13. to lure by flattery or artful talk
14. pale and deficient in color lacking vitality or interest
16. A inactive, passive, or inert
17. to annoy or harass
18. a violent censure or explosion

20. expressing sorrow or melancholy

Down

2. to meditate or muse
3. To reprove gently but earnestly
7. to grant or give as a favor to allow or permit
15. a reading
19. the door stayed _____

on the theme of
metamorphosis



For questions and submissions,
please contact us at:

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reuben.ox.ac.uk/reuby-student-magazine